

Why People Fall Out of Prayer

Romans 12 Depends on the Mortification Already Explained in Romans 8

Romans 12 says:

I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice...

The word "therefore" means Paul is basing this command on what he has already said. The offering of your body as a living sacrifice results in not being conformed to this world, but being transformed by the renewing of your mind so you can prove the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God for your life.

Paul is not only talking about revelation knowledge of the Word. He is also talking about the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God for your individual life as one member in the many-membered body of Christ.

You have a grace and calling that differs from mine. I did not place myself in my office, and you did not place yourself in yours. God has dealt to every man the measure of faith. That measure is enough to fulfill your call and appropriate everything the cross has redeemed for you.

When God opened Romans 12 to me, I was not afraid of the command to offer my body. I wanted to know how.

Works of the Flesh Cannot Produce a Living Sacrifice

I tried offering my body the way holiness people taught me. Through extreme discipline I quit smoking, quit chewing, quit going with girls who did, removed jewelry, got rid of television, and did what they told me to do.

But works of the flesh have no stopping place. Once you begin a program of self-mortification, the devil will always find one more thing to condemn you over. You can deny yourself all the way into a monastery, wearing rough clothing, sleeping sitting up, taking a vow of silence, and still not make yourself good enough.

Self-denial eventually becomes asceticism, where denial is not enough and the flesh must be tortured. But there is no end to it, because the flesh cannot make itself holy.

So I went back through Romans to find the way God had already given. Romans 8 held the key:

If ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body, ye shall live.

Then Romans 8:26 says:

Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities...

The Holy Spirit helps our weaknesses in the flesh. He makes intercession with groanings that cannot be uttered. He searches the heart, knows the mind and plan of God, and makes intercession according to the will of God.

Offering yourself as a living sacrifice means offering yourself to the Holy Spirit so He can turn you over to the death of the flesh and work both the revelation of the Word and the plan of God in your heart.

The Measure of Faith Is Seed for Your Ministry and Your Inheritance

God has delivered to every believer the measure of faith. I would be the last person to call God a liar and say He did not.

A measure is part of a whole. Each office in the body of Christ has its own measure. All the measures working together form one complete, devil-stomping, mountain-moving body of Christ.

Contained within your measure is enough faith to fulfill your ministry and appropriate everything the cross has redeemed: healing, blessing, calling, ministry, and provision.

If God told you to go to Mexico and you did not go because the money did not come, then standing before Jesus and saying, "I did not have the money," will not be enough. If He told you to go, your measure included enough faith to believe it in.

But that measure comes in seed form.

When you were born again of incorruptible seed, God deposited the programming and diagram for your life into your spirit. A corn seed carries the image of a corn stalk. A wheat seed carries the image of wheat. Your seed is different from mine because your call is different from mine.

Praying in Tongues Waters the Seed and Releases Its Program

Jesus said:

He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water.

When you pray in the Holy Ghost, you water the seed in your spirit. You cannot spend an hour praying in tongues without throwing water on that seed. Inside that seed is the programming for your entire life, your ministry, every branch, every facet, and every harvest.

The seed begins to germinate. The stalk comes up. Limbs shoot out. Leaves gather. Eventually the first harvest comes, and direction becomes settled in your spirit.

The transformation comes in two phases. First, the Word comes alive and renews your mind. Second, the call of God planted in you unfolds.

Prayer Begins the Death Process of the Living Sacrifice

When you stand before God and say, "Father, I am turning myself over to the Holy Spirit for the purpose of offering my body a living sacrifice," what begins to happen?

In the Old Testament, a living sacrifice started alive and ended dead. God does not want us physically dead, but He wants us dead to the world and alive to Him.

You cannot pray even five minutes in the Holy Ghost without the Holy Spirit attempting to turn some part of your life over as a living sacrifice. If you pray for hours, the mortification process begins more deeply. He begins to turn you over to transformation and the perfect will of God.

Isaiah 28 says:

Whom shall he teach knowledge? and whom shall he make to understand doctrine?

For precept must be upon precept... line upon line...

For with stammering lips and another tongue will he speak to this people.

Those who are weaned from milk can receive doctrine, line upon line and precept upon precept. Strong meat belongs to those who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern good and evil.

Praying in tongues allows the Holy Spirit to teach line upon line and wean us from milk to strong meat.

The Rest and Refreshing Come as the Word Purges Us

Isaiah says:

This is the rest wherewith ye may cause the weary to rest; and this is the refreshing.

Praying in tongues is connected with rest and refreshing because it offers your body as a living sacrifice and purges what keeps you from rest.

When I was born again, my inner man was created after God in righteousness and true holiness, but my outer man had not yet conformed to the inner man. I entered the kingdom with many problems.

As I prayed in the Holy Ghost, God began purging me from things that kept me from rest. It was only in recent years that the final things began to die and God ushered me into a peace I did not think possible.

Outside of receiving the baptism of the Holy Spirit, that peace is the most powerful thing I have received from the Lord Jesus Christ. Nothing has made me more unmanageable by the devil. He can threaten with everything under the sun, but that peace in my spirit makes me hard for him to manage.

The Word Comes as Light to Expose Stones and Thorns

Jesus said seed falls on wayside ground, stony ground, thorny ground, and good ground. The stones and thorns were already in the ground when the seed was sown.

But Jesus was not saying some ground is predestined to fail forever. He said a candle is not lit to be hidden under a bushel. Nothing hidden will remain hidden. The Word is sown as light in darkness so it can expose everything hidden and allow it to be purged.

Not everything the Holy Spirit wants to purge is something we want to get rid of.

That is where difficult seasons in prayer begin. At first He purges you past persecution and affliction. People treating you badly no longer makes you backslide. You have put your feet on the rock.

Then He begins dealing with the cares of this life, the slow choking process of monotony, responsibilities, and common pressures. If you keep praying, the cares of this world will not choke your ministry and call.

Then He deals with the deceitfulness of riches and the lusts of other things.

Money, Self-Exaltation, and Hidden Doors Fight the Prayer Process

As long as money owns you, you are deceived by it. Some say, "I do not have to worry about that because I do not have any." More people are destroyed chasing money than having it.

If God called you to win Mexico, then your measure includes the faith to receive the money needed. But as long as a thorn seed remains that allows money to own you, you cannot receive money from God without being choked by it.

The Holy Ghost demands every area of your life. After months or years of praying in tongues, He may begin to exert an influence on your mind: "Who owns you? Are you Mine? Give Me the key to that door."

You may not hear a voice, but emotions and fears begin to war. The more you pray, the more emotional you may feel because the Holy Spirit keeps confronting what you have not surrendered.

That is why some people go into prayer and leave feeling worse. They expected edification to feel like a spiritual charge, but something in them is declaring war against the renewed mind. The Spirit is demanding that it turn loose.

Feeling Worse in Prayer Often Means the Purge Is Working

People fall out of prayer because they hit the place where the Holy Spirit is purging something they do not want to lose.

Self-exaltation is one of those deep places. So are complacency, indifference, uncontrolled anger, and the desire to build a ministry instead of serve the kingdom.

You may pray for six months and feel less edified because the thing wrong in you has surfaced. You walk into church and someone is sitting in your chair, and suddenly your prayer life seems to depend on getting your exalted seat back.

Do not assume everyone else changed after you began praying. Your family may be the same as before, but now you are seeing what is in you.

I have learned this: the worse I feel about praying, the more I may be accomplishing by doing it. When my emotions fight hard and something in me does not want to die, that is not the time to fall out of prayer.

Even when your words feel like they are falling on the floor and you need a spatula to throw them up to heaven, you may be producing more than when prayer is flowing freely. The free flow builds your spirit to the place where the Spirit can pull what is wrong into the light and put it to death.

Stay in. Come out the other side. Something that bound you will be put to death, and the rest of your life will be different.

The Speaker's Own Pressure Broke Through Fasting and Prayer

For years I moved in and out of prayer. I would hit critical points, and they would take me out for a long time. Then I would go back in, hit the place again, and come out again.

Eventually I entered another phase. After a time of fasting, I walked into a service and the power of God began moving in a new way. My banker fell under the power and could not move for twenty minutes. I tried to reach a prayer line, and people began falling before I touched them. Once, as I prayed generally over the crowd, people began falling under the power.

For a season I ministered in that phase and was invited to camp meetings. I stood with men whose coats I once would have paid to hold in the back room.

Then something entered my life and attached itself to me. It seemed to attach to intimidation, fear of men, torment, and insecurity. It created a subtle pressure that increased year after year. The only relief came when I stopped acting as though I was going to pray, stopped getting in the Word,

and buried myself in television.

At the same time, a voice preached grace to me in a twisted way: "It is all by grace, not works. God is still using you. Prayer is works." It preached until I felt free to do worse and worse.

I watched many friends go the direction that same pressure was pushing me. When that shocked me enough, I entered into fasting and prayer more deeply. The thorn seed of intimidation, fear, and worry began to uproot. After one seeking time, I came out with the peace of God, and He said, "This is what you have been looking for, son."

That peace made me more unmanageable by the devil than anything else I had received.

Revival Is Guarded by the Flesh the Devil Keeps Irritated

There is a realm where revival lives, a tremendous outpouring of the Spirit. The devil is enraged by it. He hates anyone pressing for that realm through constant prayer, dealing with stones and thorns, crucifying flesh, and pushing on into God.

Principalities and powers camp around the perimeter of revival because they know what happens if fifty or a hundred people jump out of wheelchairs. They will have to deal with every relative and every person affected. If a thousand deaf and mute children walk out talking, the impact spreads far beyond the room.

The devil is not merely blocking healings because he hates the sick. He is blocking healings because he cannot afford the revival.

So he irritates the flesh, stirs strife, gets people mad over chairs and carpet, and keeps the church at a low level of operation.

It is not the person next to you who is the problem. It is what is surfacing in you at critical mass.

Your Life Can Still Make a Difference

Do you want to pass through your generation without making a difference? You do not have to.

You may say, "Nobody notices me." Nobody paid much attention to Anna either. She prayed and prayed, and when the promise came, she recognized Him. That was an honor God bestowed on her.

A missionary found Yonggi Cho in a city dump, living in a cardboard shack, and got him healed and born again. How would you like to be responsible for that kind of revival?

Jesus said the good ground hears the Word and brings forth thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. The candle is not lit to be hidden. The Word is given so that when you walk into the room, every obstacle hidden in darkness is revealed by the light.

That is what the Word is given for: to reveal every obstacle keeping you from producing a hundredfold.

We will continue Sunday with the basics of prayer.